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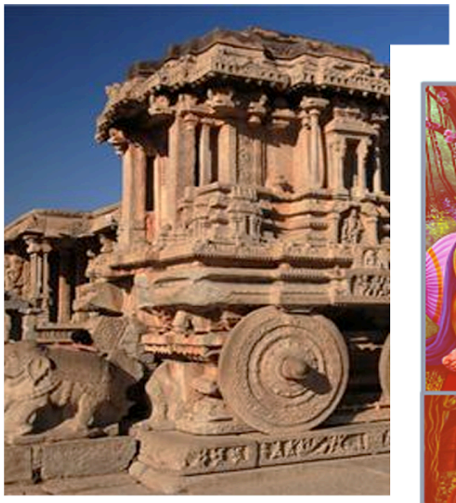
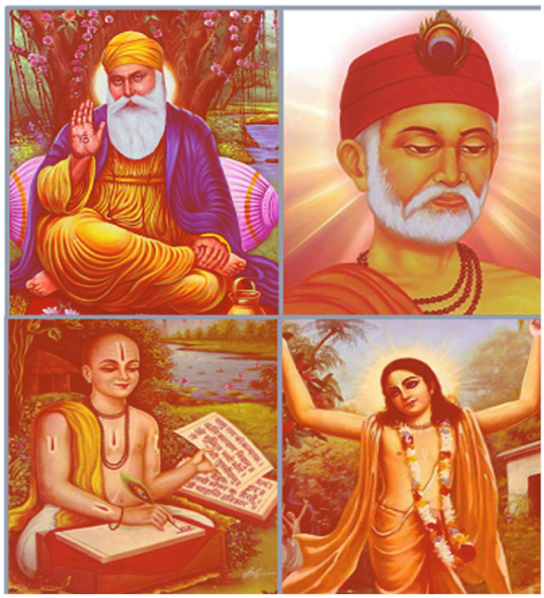
# General Knowledge
# Medieval History

## STUDY NOTES

### Humayun(1530-1540, 1555-1556)





# Humayun(1530-1540, 1555-1556)

## Ascension to the Throne

- **Nasir-ud-din Muhammad**, popularly known as Humayun, succeeded his father Babur as the ruler of the Mughal Empire in **December 1530** at the young age of 23.
- Following the Timurid tradition, Humayun divided the empire among his three half-brothers. Kamran was granted **Kabul**, **Kandahar**, **Punjab**, and the North-West Frontier; Askari was assigned Sambhal, and Hindal was given Alwar.
- This division of territories weakened Humayun's control over the empire and created administrative and military challenges. Humayun officially ascended the throne on December 30, 1530, four days after Babur's death, and established his court in Agra.

## Initial Administrative and Strategic Errors

- Humayun made several critical administrative and strategic errors early in his reign that undermined his authority. His decision to divide the empire weakened central control, as his brothers became semi-autonomous rulers.
- Furthermore, Babur's precedent of granting large estates (**jagirs**) to nobles in exchange for military support left Humayun struggling to manage an aristocracy that wielded immense power.

- These issues, combined with a lack of unity within the Mughal administration, created persistent instability.

## Early Military Campaigns

1. **Expedition to Kalinjar (1531):**

   Humayun launched an expedition against Kalinjar in Bundelkhand, believing the raja to be sympathetic to the Afghans. The Mughal army besieged Kalinjar for six months, but the siege highlighted their military shortcomings. Although the raja eventually submitted and paid compensation, the campaign demonstrated the limited effectiveness of the Mughal forces.

2. **First Siege of Chunar (1532):**

   The Afghan leader Sher Khan (later Sher Shah Suri) held the **fort** of **Chunar**, which became a strategic challenge for Humayun. The Mughal army besieged the fort for four months but failed to capture it. Humayun eventually abandoned the siege and acknowledged Sher Khan's dominance, a decision that would later cost him dearly.

3. **Battle of Dadrah or Daurah (1532):**

   In response to Afghan incursions into **the Mughal province** of **Jaunpur**, **Humayun** led his army across the **Ganges** and decisively defeated Afghan forces led by **Biban** and **Bayazid** near the **Gomti River**. Despite this victory, Sher Khan refrained from joining the Afghan forces, which some criticized as betrayal. Afghan leaders, including Sultan Mahmud Lodi, sought refuge with Bahadur Shah of Gujarat.

## Conflict with Bahadur Shah of Gujarat (1535-1536)

- Bahadur Shah, the ruler of Gujarat, had extended his influence by capturing Malwa and Raisen and providing refuge to Afghan rebels. This provoked Humayun to launch a campaign against him. After Bahadur Shah captured **Chittor** in **1535**, Humayun besieged him at Mandu.
- Bahadur Shah fled and sought refuge on the Island of Diu with Portuguese assistance. Humayun captured key forts like Mandu and Champaner but failed to maintain control over Gujarat due to administrative challenges and resistance from local chiefs. Internal dissent among Mughal nobles further weakened his hold, allowing Bahadur Shah to regain **Gujarat** in **1536**.

## Contest with Sher Shah Suri

1. **Second Siege of Chunar (1537):**

   Humayun returned to confront Sher Shah, who had consolidated power in Bihar and Bengal. After a six-month siege, Humayun captured the Chunar fort in March 1538. However, Sher Shah's power continued to grow, leading to further confrontations.

2. **Battle of Chausa (1539):**

   In June 1539, Humayun faced Sher Shah near Chausa. Despite warnings from his generals, Humayun positioned his army on the southern bank of the Ganges, which became vulnerable during the monsoon season. Heavy rains flooded the Mughal camp, and Sher Shah launched a decisive attack. The Mughal forces suffered heavy casualties, and many soldiers drowned in the Ganges. Humayun narrowly escaped death with the help of a water carrier named Nizam, whom he later rewarded by allowing him to briefly sit on the throne.

3. **Battle of Kannauj (1540):**

   After his defeat at **Chausa**, Humayun attempted to regroup his forces but faced significant challenges, including a lack of support from his brothers. In **May 1540**, Sher Shah decisively defeated Humayun's army near Kannauj. The Mughal forces were poorly trained and ill-equipped, leading to another catastrophic loss. Following this defeat, Humayun fled to Persia, where he sought refuge with Shah Tahmasp of the Safavid Empire.

## Exile and Return to Power

After his defeat, Humayun spent nearly 15 years in exile. He was warmly welcomed by Shah Tahmasp, who provided him with military support to regain his throne. In **1555**, Humayun successfully recaptured Delhi and restored the Mughal Empire. However, his return to power was short-lived, as he died in 1556 after a fatal fall from the stairs of his library.

## Key Outcomes of Humayun's Reign

- Humayun's inability to consolidate power due to administrative errors and strategic missteps weakened the Mughal Empire.
- The rise of Sher Shah Suri as a formidable leader led to the temporary loss of the empire.
- His exile in Persia allowed for cultural exchanges that influenced the Mughal court upon his return.
- Despite its setbacks, Humayun's reign paved the way for the eventual consolidation of the empire under his son Akbar.

## Important Books of the Period:

| Book Title | Author | Period Written | Significance |
|---|---|---|---|
| **Humayun Nama** | Gulbadan Begum | 16th century (after Humayun's death) | Written by Humayun's half-sister, this memoir provides a detailed account of Humayun's life, reign, and personal traits, offering unique insights into the Mughal family dynamics. |
| **Tārīkh-i-Humāyūn** | Khwandamir | 1530s | Chronicles Humayun's early reign and his challenges, providing a contemporary historical account of his rule. |
| **The Life and Times of Humayun** | Harbans Mukhia | 20th century | A modern historical analysis of Humayun's life, assessing his failures and achievements in shaping the Mughal Empire. |
| **Empire of the Moghul: Brothers at War** | Alex Rutherford | 21st century (historical fiction) | A fictional retelling of Humayun's life and struggles, providing a dramatized version of historical events. |

## Battles of Humayun

| Battle | Year | Opponent | Outcome | Significance |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| **Battle of Chausa** | June 26, 1539 | Sher Shah Suri | Defeat for Humayun. Sher Shah Suri's forces overwhelmed the Mughal army | This marked a significant setback, leading to Humayun's temporary retreat. |
| **Battle of Kannauj (Bilgram)** | May 17, 1540 | Sher Shah Suri | Defeat for Humayun. Sher Shah Suri's strategic maneuvers led to a decisive victory | Resulted in Humayun's exile and the temporary decline of Mughal power. |
| **Battle of Machchiwara** | 1955 | Afghan forces (under Adali and Sikandar Shah Suri) | Victory for Humayun | Humayun's return to India and recapture of Delhi, regaining the Mughal throne. |
| **Battle of Sirhind** | June 22, 1555 | Sikandar Shah Suri | Victory for Humayun. The Mughal forces, under his command, defeated Sikandar Shah Suri. | This led to the re-establishment of the Mughal Empire in India. |

## Architecture

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|---|---|
| | **Humayun's Tomb**<br>• Humayun's Tomb is the first garden tomb in India, featuring a Persian-style char bagh symbolizing paradise.<br>• Designed by Persian architect Mirak Mirza Ghiyas, it blends red sandstone and white marble.<br>• The tomb's distinctive double dome and tall central pishtaq reflect Persian influences.<br>• Its octagonal plan, symbolizing eternity, houses royal family members in surrounding chambers. |
| | **Charbagh**<br>• The tomb complex is set in a char bagh, a geometric layout divided into four squares by water channels, symbolizing the four rivers of paradise.<br>• This became a major feature in later Mughal tombs, including the Taj Mahal. |

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